KPPSC PMS IR Master Notes — Q4: The Abraham Accords & The Two-State Solution for Palestine

KPPSC PMS • INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS (100 MARKS)
Master Model Solution & Theoretical Deconstruction | 20 Marks Master Answer Guide

Executive Examination Metadata

Parameter	Specification
Target Examination	KPPSC PMS (Provincial Management Service) — Khyber Pakhtunkhwa
Paper & Subject	International Relations (100 Marks Optional — Group 6)
EXAM QUESTIONS LINKED:	• **2025 Q.4:** "Abraham Accord has been described as re-aligning Middle East geopolitics. Critically assess the impact of this new diplomatic architecture on the viability of the two-state solution for the Israel-Palestine conflict. Does it create new leverage for peace or further marginalize the Palestinian issue? (20 Marks)" • **2022 Q.6:** "Abraham Accords was designed to normalize relations between Israel and the Arab World; however, except for a few Arab States, the idea has not received popular support among the public and leaders. Critically examine the implications of this Accord on the Palestinian issue. (20 Marks)" • **2013 Q.5:** "Critically examine the Palestine Problem from the Balfour Declaration (1917) to the post-Oslo developments. Why has a permanent peace settlement remained elusive? (20 Marks)"
Syllabus Section	Part C: Middle East Geopolitics, Arab-Israeli Relations & Palestine Issue
Question Allocation	Attempt 1 of 5 Required (20 Marks | Strict 35-Minute Allocation)
Historiographical / Theoretical Thesis	The 2020 Abraham Accords fundamentally re-engineered Middle Eastern diplomatic architecture by discarding the historic 'land for peace' consensus established by the 2002 Arab Peace Initiative. Evaluated through the realist prism of threat convergence (anti-Iran balancing) and transactional geo-economics, the normalization between Israel and Gulf monarchies was predicated on the false premise of 'economic peace'—the belief that regional integration could proceed while bypassing Palestinian political self-determination. Rather than providing leverage for peace, the Accords systematically marginalized the Palestinian question, exacerbating structural oppression in the Occupied Territories and directly contributing to the explosive regional catastrophe of October 7, 2023, which definitively proved that Middle Eastern stability is impossible without an independent Palestinian state.

🎯 Exam Questions Linked

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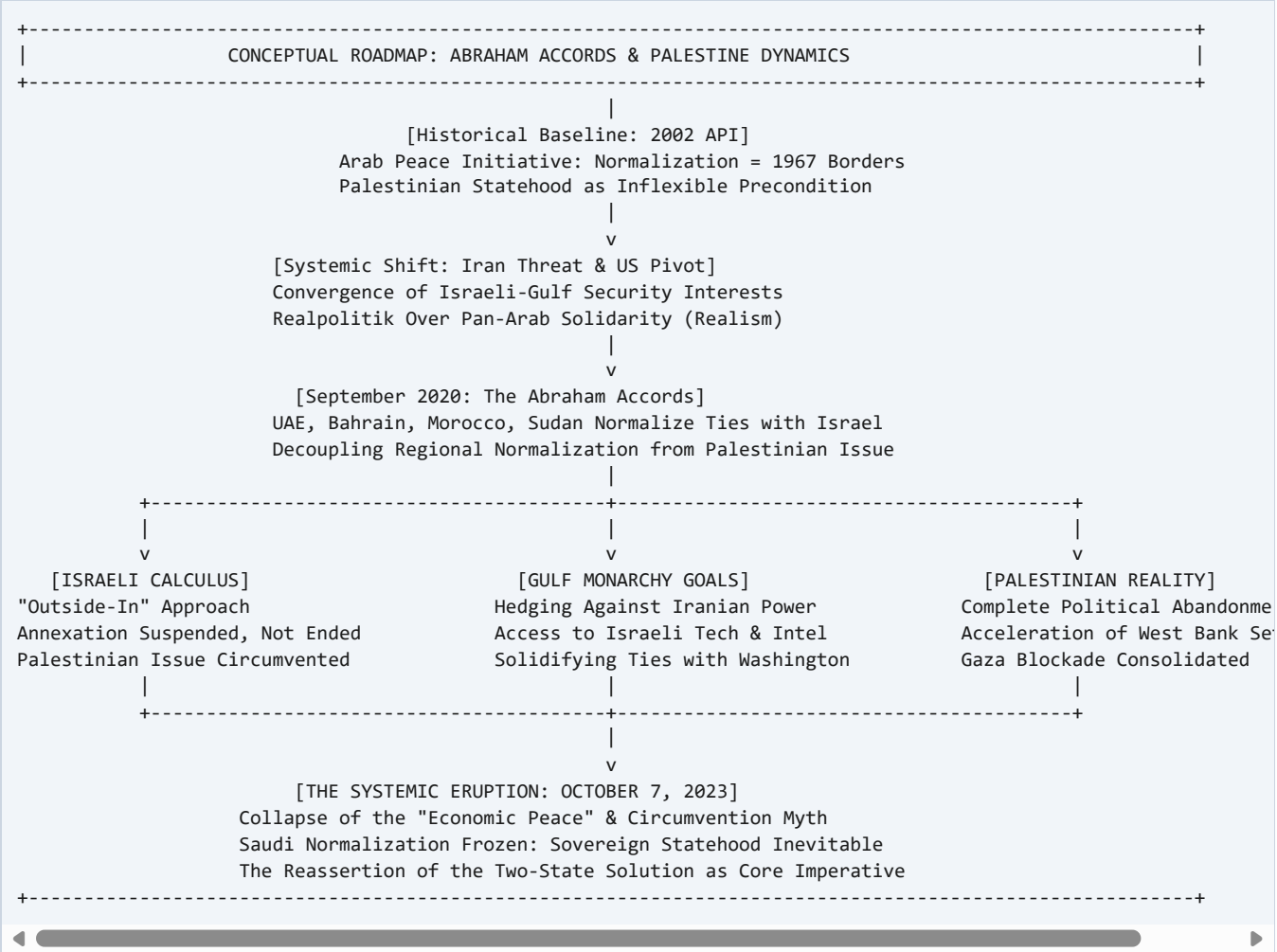
Exam Essential Takeaways

• PARADIGM SHIFT: The Accords abandoned the 2002 Arab Peace Initiative, which made normalization strictly contingent on Israeli withdrawal to 1967 borders and the establishment of a sovereign Palestinian state with East Jerusalem as its capital.

• REALIST THREAT CONVERGENCE: The driving catalyst was shared threat perception regarding the Islamic Republic of Iran's regional missile proliferation and proxy network ('Axis of Resistance'), coupled with anxieties over perceived

> American retrenchment from the Middle East.
>
> • THE 'ECONOMIC PEACE' ILLUSION: Israeli leadership (Netanyahu) promoted the doctrine that normalization, trade, cybersecurity cooperation, and technological integration could substitute for Palestinian political sovereignty.
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> • OCTOBER 7 CATACLYSM & THE RETURN OF PALESTINE: The eruption of the Hamas-Israel war shattered the normalization paradigm, freezing Saudi-Israeli normalization talks and compelling international recognition that the two-state solution is an existential necessity, not an optional luxury.

Conceptual Thematic Map & Strategic Roadmap



Analytical Dimensions & Systemic Shifts Matrix

Dimension / Arena	Strategic Mechanism / Driver	Systemic Impact on Global Order
2002: Arab Peace Initiative (API)	Beirut Arab League Summit; offered full normalization in exchange for Israeli withdrawal to 1967 borders.	Established the foundational pan-Arab diplomatic consensus linking normalization to Palestinian sovereign statehood.
September 2020: Abraham Accords Signed	US-brokered normalization agreements signed by Israel, UAE, and Bahrain; later Morocco and Sudan.	Decoupled normalization from Palestinian statehood, marking a radical structural realignment based on transactional realpolitik.
2021–2022: Geo-economic Integration	Bilateral trade between UAE and Israel crossed $2.5B; defense, cyber, and intelligence agreements signed.	Promoted the illusion that Middle Eastern security could be organized around an anti-Iran axis while ignoring the occupation.
Mid-2023: US-Saudi-Israel Mega-Deal Talks	Biden administration actively brokered normalization between Saudi Arabia and Israel in exchange for security pacts.	Brought the Palestinian issue to the absolute brink of permanent geopolitical obsolescence.

Dimension / Arena	Strategic Mechanism / Driver	Systemic Impact on Global Order
October 7, 2023 – Present: Regional War	Hamas launched Operation Al-Aqsa Flood; massive Israeli military campaign in Gaza and Lebanon.	Destroyed the circumvention paradigm; Saudi Arabia affirmed that normalization is impossible without an irreversible path to Palestinian statehood.

The 20-Mark Master Model Essay (~650-700 Words)

Introduction: The Diplomatic Metamorphosis of Middle Eastern Realignment

Signed on the White House South Lawn in September 2020 under the stewardship of the Trump administration, the Abraham Accords—facilitating the formal normalization of diplomatic relations between Israel and the United Arab Emirates, Bahrain, and subsequently Morocco and Sudan—represented the most radical restructuring of Middle Eastern diplomacy in four decades. For nearly half a century, pan-Arab diplomacy had been anchored to the principle of 'land for peace,' formalized in the 2002 Arab Peace Initiative (API). The API explicitly held that Arab normalization with Tel Aviv was contingent upon Israeli withdrawal from the territories occupied in 1967 and the establishment of a sovereign, independent Palestinian state with East Jerusalem as its capital. The Abraham Accords demolished this consensus, pioneering an 'outside-in' diplomatic architecture that decoupled Arab recognition of Israel from the resolution of the Palestinian national question. However, viewed through the lens of critical international relations and empirical reality, this realignment did not unlock genuine regional peace; instead, it operated on the fatal illusion of 'economic peace,' directly contributing to the cataclysm of October 7, 2023.

Realist Drivers: Threat Convergence and the Anti-Iran Imperative

The catalyst behind the Abraham Accords was not an ideational breakthrough regarding coexistence, but cold, hard structural realpolitik. Through Stephen Walt's balance-of-threat theory, states align against proximate, aggressive capabilities rather than abstract moral principles. For the Gulf monarchies—particularly the UAE and Bahrain—the perceived retrenchment of American security commitments across the Middle East, combined with the expanding ballistic missile capabilities and asymmetric proxy network of the Islamic Republic of Iran (the 'Axis of Resistance'), generated an acute security dilemma. Israel, possessing undisputed regional military superiority, advanced intelligence capabilities, and unmatched cyber-defense infrastructure, emerged as a natural balance-of-power partner. In exchange for formal diplomatic ties, the Gulf states gained access to advanced Israeli defense systems (such as air-defense integration and Pegasus cyber-intelligence) while solidifying bipartisan security patronage in Washington.

The Circumvention Strategy: Marginalization of the Palestinian Question

For the government of Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, the Abraham Accords represented the triumphant vindication of Ze'ev Jabotinsky's 'Iron Wall' doctrine—the thesis that Arabs would only reconcile with Israel once they realized Jewish sovereignty could not be broken. By securing peace treaties with prominent Arab nations without conceding a single inch of occupied territory or halting settlement expansion in the West Bank, Netanyahu successfully bypassed the Palestinian issue. The accords reduced the Palestinian national struggle from an existential question of political self-determination and statehood to a transactional matter of humanitarian aid and economic subsidies. Western and regional diplomats championed the illusion that cross-border capital investments, tourism, and high-tech trade would naturally pacify the Occupied Territories. In reality, the accords deeply disenfranchised the Palestinian population, completely delegitimizing the moderate Palestinian Authority and entrenching the despair that empowered militant rejectionist factions.

The Systemic Collapse of the 'Economic Peace' Paradigm

The catastrophic eruption of the Hamas-led assault on October 7, 2023, and the ensuing regional war in Gaza, Lebanon, and across the Red Sea decisively shattered the core premise of the Abraham Accords. The violence proved beyond ambiguity that regional integration cannot be engineered on the burial grounds of Palestinian aspirations. The circumvention strategy collapsed precisely because peace between distant monarchies in the Persian Gulf could never substitute for a negotiated settlement with the millions of Palestinians living under occupation. Crucially, the momentum toward the ultimate prize of the Accords—Saudi-Israeli normalization—was brought to an abrupt halt. Riyadh, recognizing domestic public fury and the systemic imperative of pan-Islamic legitimacy, unequivocally recalibrated its foreign policy, declaring that diplomatic normalization with Israel is unconditionally contingent upon an irreversible, time-bound pathway toward a sovereign Palestinian state based on 1967 borders.

Conclusion: The Irreplaceable Necessity of Sovereign Palestinian Statehood

In conclusion, while the Abraham Accords demonstrated the capacity of realist threat perceptions to realign bilateral state interests, they fundamentally failed as a holistic framework for regional peace. By treating the Palestinian question as a peripheral nuisance rather than the core root of Middle Eastern instability, the accords created a fragile diplomatic facade that masked boiling structural oppression. The post-October 7 landscape has forced an inescapable international consensus: the two-state solution is not an obsolete relic, but the only viable geopolitical formula capable of ensuring long-term Israeli security, Palestinian sovereignty, and authentic Middle Eastern stability. Any diplomatic architecture that attempts to construct regional integration without resolving the sovereign rights of the Palestinians will inevitably collapse into recurrent cycles of catastrophic violence.

Theoretical Perspectives & Quotable Thesis Arguments

Theorist / Scholar	Theoretical School	Exact Quotable Thesis Argument
Avi Shlaim	*The Iron Wall: Israel and the Arab World*	"The Abraham Accords were not a peace treaty; they were an arms-and-business transaction between authoritarian regimes and Israel, designed to bypass the core moral and political issue of the Middle East—the dispossession of the Palestinians."
Rashid Khalidi	*The Hundred Years' War on Palestine*	"The Abraham Accords represented a brazen attempt to liquidate the Palestinian issue by treating Palestinians as invisible subjects while integrating Israel into an authoritarian regional security order."
John J. Mearsheimer	*Structural Realism*	"The idea that you could normalize relations with the Arab world and ignore the Palestinians was pure hubris. Realist logic dictates that oppressed populations will inevitably resist domination, and that regional stability cannot be sustained on unresolved territorial conquest."
Fawaz Gerges	*Middle East International Relations*	"The Abraham Accords prioritized an anti-Iran security alliance over the historic pan-Arab commitment to Palestinian statehood. October 7 was the bloody reassertion that Palestine remains the beating heart of Middle Eastern politics."
Vali Nasr	*Geopolitical Analysis*	"The Abraham Accords attempted to freeze Middle Eastern geopolitics around an Arab-Israeli axis against Iran. But by ignoring the Palestinian core, it built an edifice on sand that collapsed the moment the local status quo exploded."